

Φίλιστος ὁ Συρακούσιος

Philistus of Syracuse and the Histories of Sicily

eul_aid: drk

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic \(frg\)](#)

Domain: [Ἱστορία](#) [History](#)

Format: [Πεζός](#) [Prose](#)

Philistus of Syracuse was a Syracusan historian and statesman active from approximately 432 to 356 BCE. A contemporary and staunch supporter of the tyrants Dionysius I and Dionysius II, he held significant military and political offices, including command of the Syracusan citadel and fleet. He was exiled by Dionysius I, likely around 386 BCE, and spent this period composing his historical work before being recalled by Dionysius II. Philistus remained loyal to the younger tyrant, commanding the fleet against Dion until his defeat, capture, and subsequent execution by the Syracusan populace in 356 BCE.

His major work was the **Sikelika**, a history of Sicily in thirteen books. The first seven books covered events up to 406 or 405 BCE, while the final six provided a detailed account of the reign of Dionysius I. The work is now lost and survives only in fragments. Philistus was a major historian of the western Greek world, highly regarded in antiquity for his concise and serious style, which drew comparison to Thucydides. As a participant and apologist for the Dionysian tyranny, his perspective colored his narrative, later attracting criticism from philosophers such as Plutarch. His detailed account served as a crucial source for later historians, including Ephorus, Timaeus, and Diodorus Siculus.

Works (1)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα τῶν Σικελικῶν Ἱστοριῶν](#) · [Fragments of Sicilian Histories](#) · 69 passages